



Modern adventures in printing

Explore the process of printing with movable type, and find out what a bodkin, chase or forme is. <http://digit.in/feb21-93>



The Magazine Rack

Here's an archive of free digitized magazines on subjects ranging from computers to humour to sports. <http://digit.in/feb21-94>

with a template that demonstrates the look and feel of the entire publication, with dummy text and placeholder art to show how type and images will be positioned within a page.

COPY

The copy is the actual textual content, which is hammered out on keyboards by underpaid writers. The editor then compares the text to a style guide, which has all kinds of important details to maintain consistency, such as whether to use % or percent, what kind of dates to use, when text should be highlighted or emphasized, and in what way, and the detailed rules on how to write numbers. For example it might be easier to comprehend “a hundred million exoplanets” as well as “239 vaccines” than using the text and numbers switched out in these examples. Then there are a detailed checklist of common errors, such as: “Use ‘you’ instead of ‘u’.”

Once the editor has made corrections to the text, resolved any conflicts of style, proofread the document, and made the necessary corrections, it is passed on to the layout artist. The layout artist then commands a typesetting software, setting the necessary parameters for print, after which there is another round of editing for “fitting” the content to the available space. If you see hastily ended stories in newspapers, this is the reason for that, but traditionally trained journalists know to structure stories in such a way that you can chop off as much as you want from the bottom.

The information coolies working for content farms that are essentially weblogs calling themselves “news sites” do all of these things at once, often on a single console. The editorial considerations here are mainly for the benefit of Google rankings, which is typically coded into the CMS software (AKA blogging platform) used as a backend for the website. It checks the use of power words in headlines as well as sufficient use of keywords in the intro, or if you want to be old school, the kicker. The

platform dictates that the length of the intro be just long enough to be fully read when the link is shared on instant messaging platforms. These are the essential priorities for digital publications. There is no typesetting or formatting or layout and design considerations for each story, and the positioning of images as well as the overall layout is decided in the software by the writers themselves, who might not really be trained in graphic design principles. A style guide, if it exists, is often ignored.

ART

The fact that visuals are striking is not lost on print publications. At least the good publications such as Scientific American and Wired, focus more on conveying information than just filling up the pages with text. There may be entire pages dedicated to just high resolution photographs. At times these might even be commissioned, which requires additional planning and scouting. Based on the story ideas and design brief, graphic artists may produce digital artwork and infographics.

There are few digital publications that focus on original art or photos for every article, and most typically source their images from press releases, stock photography websites, syndicated news image services, or the lazy reporter might even pick an image up randomly from the internet without bothering about the rights and attribution. The result is that there are a whole bunch of trending stories on the same thing with the same image, and digital publications have still not found a cost effective way of producing original images, even though mighty Google does not like it, at all. WikiHow managed to rise to the top of search rankings primarily because of original art.

PRODUCTION CYCLE

Most magazines and periodicals work in production cycles that typically last eight weeks for a single issue. A newsletter or a bulletin takes four.

Sourcing the content is done based on editorial considerations and pitches from writers. A story list is prepared, along with storyboards for each of the articles. The concept of the piece is conveyed to the designer, copywriter, illustrator and photographer, who all work on their parts at the appropriate time in the pipeline. The piece travels through the office from execution to approval to execution of another round till finally the magazine is sent to print. The pages are made up of formes that fill up a printing plate. Most printing presses use the larger paper sizes such as B1 or B2, that are then cut up and folded into the final pages. The plate can be made up of plastic, rubber, or metal, and is a relief of a set of pages on the forme, that is pressed against the paper to print the content. The pages are then cut, bound, packaged, and sent off for distribution.

Coming to the part that can be shortened as needed, the production cycles in print are tight, but not hectic like digital, where all the news houses rush to come up with the Google Doodle story within minutes of it going live, as that is going to get a lot of hits. The print reporters in The Caravan or Frontline have more time to chew on the stories before reporting them, resulting in deeper, comprehensive coverage. The content captured in print is a time capsule. That old magazine in the Doctor's Office with the salacious gossip from 2006, is a time capsule, and so is the National Geographic Return to Mars issue from August 1998 that had stunning anaglyphic panoramas of Mars, along with the cardboard glasses to view them in 3D. Good print unites the readers across space and time. Print cannot be deleted, it has to be burned! Print can be hidden away, in bits and pieces, and reinvented in scrapbooks, collages or decoupage. The only thing you can do with a blog is copy paste it. The latest data from the Indian Readership Survey actually shows print subscribers increasing, which is a great indication that print is here to stay. 